Prima dată — money, the first time, done right

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In one screen

Problem. Romanians under 30 make their first money decisions alone, with the lowest financial knowledge in the EU (13% score high). The rules that shape their future are Romanian and change every year: where a salary's contributions go, a pension fund they never chose, inflation eating their deposits, 16% tax on gains from app-based brokers. Generic finance courses don't explain any of it, and nobody explains it at the moment it matters.

Solution. Prima dată ("the first time") is a Brilliant-style app where the exercises are your own life.

- Lessons arrive when a financial "first" happens: first payslip, first savings, first investing app, first freelance contract, first tax return.
- Each lesson uses your own numbers.
- Each lesson ends in one real action: a savings rule on payday, a decision about your pension fund, your tax figures for the 25 May deadline.

Who pays. Users never pay, and nobody can pay to be recommended.

- Banks, neobanks and brokers license the lessons inside their own apps, paying per active learner, because they need young customers who actually start saving and investing.
- Employers pay per seat to onboard their first-job hires.

Verdict. Projected **≈4.1/5** on the jury weights, up from 3.2 for the original "education app + referral fees" version. The redesign keeps your focus on the young generation and fixes the two things the jury would punish: "just presenting information" and a conflicted business model.

The problem

The decisions that shape a Romanian's financial future start in their twenties, and the system makes them for you unless you understand it.

- **Knowledge.** 13% of Romanians have high financial knowledge, the lowest in the EU. 25% have no emergency savings (EU: 16%). Financial education in schools has been optional since a 2018 agreement between BNR, ASF, the Ministries of Education and Finance and the banking association, so most under-30s never had it.

- **The pension you never chose.** Employees under 35 must join a Pillar II fund within 4 months of being hired. Those who don't pick one are assigned a fund in proportion to market share. In 2012, 95.75% of new participants were assigned that way. About 4.75% of every gross salary goes there.
- **Inflation vs savings.** At July 2026's 8.2% inflation, 10,000 lei in a 4.5% deposit (after the 10% interest tax) lost about **384 lei** of purchasing power in a year. Even the top 7.6% tax-free Fidelis rate lost about 55 lei.
- **Investing apps and tax.** Since 2026, gains through a Romanian broker that withholds tax are taxed at 3% (held over a year) or 6%. Through a broker that doesn't withhold, typically a foreign app, the rate is 16% and you must file Declarația Unică by 25 May yourself. Investment income above 24,300 lei a year also triggers CASS (health contribution).
- **The rules move every year.** 2026 changed capital-gains rates, raised the minimum wage mid-year (thresholds didn't move) and pushed tens of thousands of young people into PFA contracts (+71% new PFAs in Q1).

The gap isn't access to information; banks, brokers and creators publish plenty. It's that nothing meets you at the moment you act, uses your own numbers, and helps you do the right thing then.

Who it serves

First user: the first 90 days of the first full-time job. Maria, 23, a junior data analyst in Iași (synthetic persona).

- She earns 6,000 lei gross.
- She has Revolut and a broker app she opened after a TikTok video, and no savings.
- She doesn't know what Pillar II is, which fund she's in, or that her broker's gains may need a tax return.
- Her parents keep their money in deposits and tell her to buy an apartment.

The first job is the sharpest moment: the first payslip arrives, the pension fund deadline runs, and the first money with no parents watching lands in her account.

Mass market. About **2.0 million** Romanians aged 20–29 (Eurostat estimate, 1 Jan 2025: 1.02M aged 20–24, 0.99M aged 25–29). Then everyone up to 35 as new "firsts" arrive: a freelance contract, moving out, a first loan, a first home.

Who pays is not the user. Banks, neobanks and brokers fighting for these customers pay, and so do employers hiring them (see Business model). Two signals of how contested this segment is:

- Revolut has about 5 million retail customers in Romania (September 2026).

- Banca Transilvania launched the digital bank Salt Bank, which had ~500,000 clients after its first year and targets 1 million by the end of 2026.

The product

Four rules that make it more than an education app:

1. **Triggered by a moment, not a syllabus.** A lesson opens when a "first" happens: payday, a balance building up, a broker deposit, a job offer, the tax deadline. No streaks for their own sake.
2. **Your numbers, not examples.** Every exercise runs on the user's payslip, balance or trades, typed in or photographed; with a licensed partner later, read from the bank.
3. **Predict, then see.** The Brilliant mechanic: guess first ("how much of your gross goes to your future?"), then a slider-driven reveal. 3–5 minutes per moment.
4. **Every moment ends in one action** the user chooses at their own bank or broker. Progress is counted in actions done, not quiz points.

The moments library (Romania, 2026 rules):

Moment	Trigger	What you learn, with your own numbers	The action
First payslip	First salary lands, or a payslip photo	Where gross goes: 25% to pension (4.75% of gross into *your* Pillar II account), 10% health, 10% income tax; which fund you were assigned	Check your fund; set a "pay yourself first" rule for payday
First savings	A balance building up; the monthly inflation figure	Real return after the 10% tax and inflation; emergency buffer; how Tezaur and Fidelis work (monthly windows, 5,000 lei Fidelis minimum, tax-free)	A buffer target with an automatic transfer; the next state-bond window in your calendar
First investing app	First deposit or trade	3%/6% withheld vs 16% self-declared; the 25 May deadline; the CASS threshold; fees; funds vs single stocks	Export your trades and get your tax figures and a reminder

Moment	Trigger	What you learn, with your own numbers	The action
First freelance (PFA) offer	An offer as PFA vs employment contract	Contributions jump at 48,600 and 97,200 lei net; the CASS floor; the pension contributions you no longer get automatically	Compare the two offers in net and future terms; set a tax-reserve rule
First bonus	A lump sum lands	Buffer first, then goals; the €400/year Pillar III deduction	Split it by rule
First tax return	April–May	What Declarația Unică is and when it applies to you	A personal checklist with your figures

One moment end to end: the first payslip

1. On payday Maria gets one nudge: "Your first payslip, explained in 3 minutes."
2. **Predict:** a slider asks how much of her 6,000 lei gross goes to her future. She guesses 300 lei.
3. **Reveal:** she photographs the payslip. **1,500 lei** went to her pension, **285 lei** of it into her own Pillar II account, plus 600 lei to health. Moving the gross slider shows how each part changes.
4. **The fund nobody chose:** how she was assigned, and the funds compared on public data (fees, returns), with no recommendation. Action: check her fund on the Pillar II portal.
5. **Pay yourself first:** her three months of expenses become a buffer target. She picks an amount to move to savings on payday at her own bank (simulated in the prototype).
6. Her "firsts map" marks the payslip done and schedules the next moment, when the monthly inflation figure comes out.

Business model

Don't sell leads; sell activation. Partners pay for young customers who actually start saving and investing, inside the partner's own app, and the lessons stay neutral.

Stream	Who pays	What they buy	Pricing (to test)	When
Partner licence (main)	Banks, neobanks, brokers	The moments embedded in their app (white-label), with the action completed in their product: payday savings rule set up, first state-bond order placed, first recurring investment started	Per monthly active learner, or annual licence plus per-learner fee	Month 6
Employer seats	Companies hiring many under-30s (IT, outsourcing centres, retail chains)	First-job onboarding: payslip, pension fund, PFA vs contract, buffer. Fewer money-stressed new hires	Per employee per year, sold directly or through benefit platforms	Month 3
Standalone app	Nobody	The free app is the funnel and the proof of engagement for partners	Free, no ads	Day 1

Neutrality rules (put them on a slide):

- Nobody can pay to be recommended. When options are compared, they're ranked by a public formula: return after tax and inflation, minus fees.
- Partners pay the same rate whatever their rank, and the user always chooses where to act.
- No individual investment recommendations: explain instruments and options, never "buy this fund".
- No ads, and no selling user data.

Why partners pay even when we're neutral:

- The license is for *their* app. The lesson runs there, and the action (a savings rule, a first state-bond order) happens there.
- They pay for young customers who become active, which their own marketing struggles to buy. Revolut's 5 million Romanian customers and Salt Bank's 1-million target show how hard they compete.

- The industry already funds financial education: BNR, ASF and the banking association signed a schools agreement in 2018.
- Abroad, Zogo built a youth financial-education app on 200+ bank and credit-union partners, reaching ~700,000 mostly under-24 users by 2022.

Your original idea, kept honestly. Referral fees per savings account can stay as a minor stream, under the neutrality rules. Don't build the company on them: young savers hold small balances, so each account is worth little to a bank. And getting paid to push the product you just taught about breaks trust with an audience that already distrusts banks.

Validate before demo day (one call each):

- [ ] One bank or neobank (Salt Bank, ING, BCR) or broker: would they embed moments and pay per active learner?
- [ ] One HR lead at an IT or outsourcing company: would they pay per seat for first-job onboarding?
- [ ] Ten people under 30: after the payslip moment, did they take the action?

Go-to-market and scaling

The free app earns trust and proves which moments lead to action. Partners and employers pay for the version inside their world.

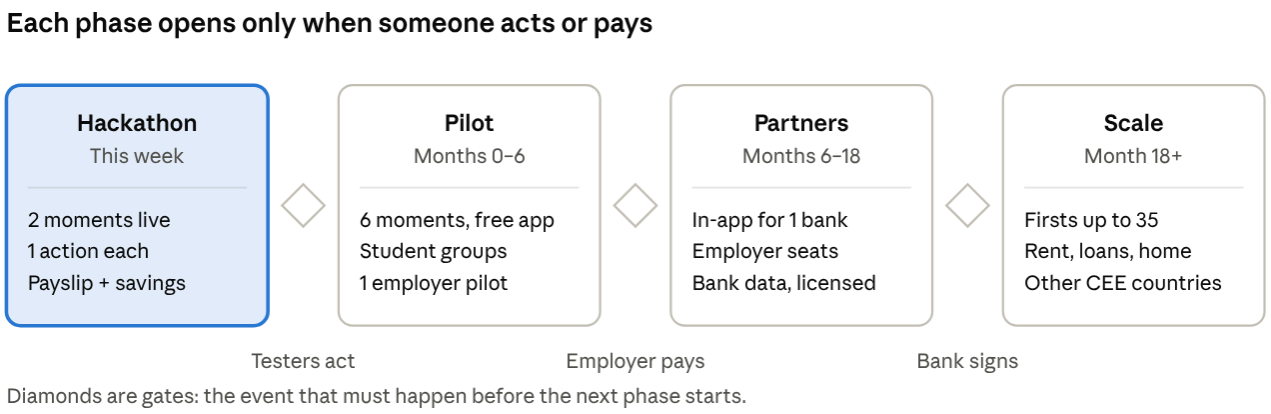
Channels, cheapest first:

- **Student organizations** at the big universities (ASE, Politehnica, UBB): a "your first job" session before graduation.
- **Employer onboarding:** HR sends the payslip moment with the first salary.
- **Short Romanian videos** cut from the moments themselves ("guess how much of your salary goes to your pension").
- **Inside partner apps**, once a licence is signed.

Why people come back: the calendar, not streaks. Payday every month, the monthly inflation figure, monthly state-bond windows, the 25 May tax deadline, and each new "first".

North-star metric: actions completed per user per quarter. It's what partners pay for, and it's the proof of "tangible value" the brief asks for.

Moat: lesson content is easy to copy. A rules engine that stays correct every year (thresholds, tax rates, deadlines) is not, and neither are partner integrations or data on which moments actually lead to action.



Roadmap · 4 phases, 3 gates · not to scale

Each phase is unlocked by evidence, not by the calendar: testers who act, then an employer who pays, then a bank that signs.

Why Romania, and how it maps to the brief

Only in Romania. Every moment runs on Romanian rules that change yearly:

- the 25% pension contribution with 4.75% routed to Pillar II;
- assignment to a pension fund for those who don't choose one;
- 10% tax on deposit interest vs tax-free Tezaur/Fidelis with monthly windows;
- 3%/6% withheld vs 16% self-declared on investment gains;
- PFA contributions in steps set by the minimum wage.

Copied to another country, the moments are wrong. That's also the scaling path: a new country is a new rule pack, not a new app.

Why now: 2026 brought new investment-gain tax rates, inflation of 8.2% against deposits paying 4.4–5.25%, a record year for Fidelis and the PFA wave. Banks and neobanks are competing hard for young customers.

The brief says	Prima dată
"people face different questions at different stages of life"	Built around life's financial "firsts", the stage when habits form
"information can be difficult to understand"	Predict-then-see on your own numbers, 3–5 minutes per moment
"relevance depends on individual circumstances"	Each lesson uses your payslip, balance or trades

The brief says	Prima dată
"new instruments, changing regulations"	Pillar II, Tezaur/Fidelis, 2026 investment taxes, PFA thresholds
"go beyond presenting information"	Every moment ends in one action the user takes
Trust and confidence	Nobody pays to be recommended; the ranking formula is public

Demo script and build plan

The wow moment is the reveal: a payslip photo turns into "1,500 lei of your salary went to your pension, 285 lei into a fund you never chose". Then the business story shows the same moment running inside a bank's app.

Time	On screen	What you say
0:00–0:20	Maria's photo, then a question to the room	"Maria got her first salary last week. Quick question: who here knows which Pillar II fund they're in? Most people were assigned one. Maria was too."
0:20–1:15	**Live:** the predict slider (she guesses 300 lei), payslip photo, the reveal, the gross slider, neutral fund comparison, then she sets a payday savings rule	"We don't tell her, we let her guess, then show her real numbers. 1,500 lei to her pension, 285 into her own account. Then one action: pay yourself first, at her own bank."
1:15–1:50	Two weeks later: the inflation figure lands; her balance loses about 384 lei per 10,000 in real terms; how Tezaur/Fidelis work; the next window goes in her calendar	"Every moment is triggered by her life, not a syllabus, and every moment ends in something done."
1:50–2:15	The firsts map; the same payslip moment inside a mock bank app	"This is the product banks buy: the moment inside their app, with the action completed there."
2:15–2:40	Business slide	"Banks, neobanks and brokers pay per active learner. Employers pay per first-job hire. Users pay nothing, and nobody pays to be recommended."

Time	On screen	What you say
2:40–3:00	Limits slide + close	"Education, not advice. Actions simulated, 2026 rules. Prima dată: money, the first time, done right."

Build plan (5 engineers, ~24 build hours):

Who	Builds	Real or mocked
Engineer 1	Payslip reader: photo → gross, contributions, net, with manual entry as fallback	Real
Engineer 2	2026 rules engine shared by all moments: payslip split, real return after tax and inflation, investment tax (3%/6%/16%) and the CASS thresholds; 15+ tests	Real
Engineer 3	Moment player: predict slider, animated reveal, live sliders, the firsts map; mobile-first	Real
Engineer 4	Actions and partner view: mock bank for the savings rule, state-bond window calendar, the same moment rendered inside a mock bank app (white-label)	Mocked partner, real UI
Engineer 5	Romanian copy for the 2 moments (checked by someone who knows the rules), the validation calls, pitch, video, backup recording	—

If time runs short, cut in this order: the firsts map → the second moment (keep one slide) → the live partner view (keep a screenshot). Never cut predict → reveal → action on the payslip.

Scores

Projected **4.1/5**, scored the same way as the other tabs. The original education-app-plus-referrals version scores 3.2.

Criterion	Weight	Original	Prima dată	What the score depends on
Fit & differentiation	20%	3	4	Romanian rules in every moment, ending in actions. Still a crowded category: some teams will show a finance-learning app.
User experience	25%	4	4.5	Predict-then-see on your own numbers, 3–5 minutes, one action. The strongest criterion.
Technical	25%	3	4	Payslip reading plus a tested 2026 rules engine. Drops to 3 if the numbers are hard-coded.
Delivery & pitch	20%	3	4	The "which fund are you in?" question to the room is the hook. 4.5 if it lands.
Business	10%	2.5	4	Activation licences and employer seats, with neutrality rules. No partner validated yet.
Weighted		**3.2**	**4.1**	

To push it higher: read real transactions from a Romanian bank's open-banking sandbox (Tech to 4.5). Show one partner's reaction or a letter of intent (Business to 5). Make the reveal land in the room (Pitch to 4.5). With all three, it gets to about 4.45.

Honest comparison: Anii tăi (previous tab) projects 4.55 because its value is a lei figure only Romania produces. Prima dată keeps your focus on the young generation, where the financial future is longest, and has the cleaner path to recurring revenue. Pick the one your team can demo best.

Regulation, risks and limits

The main risk is drifting from education into advice or selling. The neutrality rules are the mitigation, so make them visible.

- **Investment advice.** Recommending a specific instrument to a specific person is investment advice under MiFID II, licensed by ASF. Explaining instruments and showing options with a public ranking is education. Introducing clients to an investment firm for pay may need tied-agent registration (**verify** with ASF).
- **Credit products.** Any loan comparison or referral for pay may require registration as a credit intermediary (**verify**). Leave credit out of the first version.

- **Tax figures.** Calculating a user's own figures is fine; tax consultancy is a regulated profession. Show the formulas, link to ANAF, never file for the user (**verify** where the line sits).
- **Data.** Payslips and trades are personal data under GDPR: consent per document, minimal storage, deletion on request. Reading bank data later needs a licensed open-banking partner (Smart Fintech holds both BNR licences).
- **Partner conflict.** A bank may not like a lesson showing that state bonds beat its deposit. The licence must say partners can't edit the comparisons; banks that also sell Fidelis have less reason to object.
- **Retention.** Education apps lose users fast. The defence is calendar-driven moments and actions, not content volume. Measure actions, not opens.
- **Accuracy.** The 2026 rules change every year, so the engine needs an annual update and a reviewer who knows the rules. Every number shows its formula and its year.
- **Prototype limits.** Payslips and balances are typed or photographed, partner and bank actions are simulated, and only 2 moments are built.

Sources

Figures from your own brief (13% financial knowledge, 25% without emergency savings, inflation, deposit and Fidelis rates, Pillar II contribution, new PFAs) are used as given. Everything else:

- Population aged 20–24 and 25–29, Romania, 1 Jan 2025 — Eurostat estimates
- Under-35s must join Pillar II within 4 months; random assignment by market share — Mediafax, 8 Apr 2008
- 95.75% of 2012's new Pillar II participants assigned at random — Wall-Street.ro
- Investment gains in 2026: 3%, 6% or 16%; CASS thresholds — Financiarul, 20 Oct 2026
- Financial education in schools is optional (2018 agreement: Ministry of Education, BNR, MFP, ASF, Romanian Banking Association) — Fiscalitatea, 24 Jul 2018
- Revolut reaches 5 million retail customers in Romania — Romania Insider, 30 Sep 2026
- Salt Bank targets 1 million clients by end of 2026 — Bursa, 10 Apr 2025
- Zogo signs 200+ financial-institution partners, ~700,000 mostly under-24 users — CUInsight, 21 Jun 2022
- Smart Fintech licensed by BNR for account information and payment initiation — Financial Intelligence, Oct 2021